One person who of course was not consulted about any of this was Shah Shuja – the man in whose name the war had been waged and the occupation administered. His biographer Mohammad Husain Herati gives the only surviving account of the Shah's reaction when he heard of the terms which had been offered by Macnaghten, his one-time champion:

> When His Majesty got intelligence of this agreement, he wrote to Macnaghten as follows: 'Did you bring us back to this country only to hand us over to our enemies? Have you still no idea of the faithlessness of the Barakzais and of the people of this country? By throwing money at these vengeful people, you are only hastening your own and our death and destruction! Is that sensible?' Macnaghten merely countered: 'It is too late to change the agreements that have been made.' His Majesty was distraught, running hither and thither like liquid mercury, wringing his hands day and night, saying 'Macnaghten has taken leave of his senses – it will be the death of both of us!'

Macnaghten ordered the remaining British troops to leave the Bala Hisar and despatched a message to inform Akbar Khan that the fort had been evacuated and that he should send his own troops to garrison it.

> Mohammad Akbar Khan immediately sent 2,000 jezail-bearing Ghilzais. The decent citizens of Kabul were horrified, exclaiming 'If Akbar Khan takes over the fort, what will happen to Shah Shuja's womenfolk and children and dependants? God help them!'
>
> At the thought of the imminent rape and pillage, His Majesty was sunk in a whirlpool of despondency. However the denizens of the Bala Hisar fort were mostly old retainers, born within the compound, loyal servants who had grown up under the protection and patronage of the royal family: these at least did not weakly give in to despair, and as soon as the last of the English forces had marched out of the fort, they boldly shut the gates behind them and killed any of the rebel soldiers who had already penetrated the fort, so that Akbar Khan's troops were forced to retire disappointed.[102]

Akbar Khan's troops tried twice more to assault the main gate of the Bala Hisar, but Shah Shuja's household troops, whom the British had long disparaged as 'a useless rabble', successfully drove them back, inflicting serious casualties. 'We could not but admire the promptitude and courage he [Shuja] had displayed on this very critical occasion,' wrote Lawrence, 'and heartily desired that a similar energy might be shown by our own leaders, who still appeared quite incapable of adopting any measures to secure our honour and our safety.'[103]

As the British buckled and surrendered, ignoring all Shuja's warnings, the Shah remained strong and successfully held out in the Bala Hisar until he